appointed their own imams as their spiritual leaders. Oman's economy is based mainly on oil revenues, but it does not have oil reserves the size of Saudi Arabia's or Iran's. Its oil resources are depleting, which requires them to manage their economy wisely and cautiously.

The Mossad also had a presence in Oman, with the intensity of our activity there adapting according to changing needs and conditions. Prime Minister Rabin, as well as his predecessor, Shamir, attached great importance to our presence in the territory. Rabin, perhaps because of being a former military man, wanted to see and hear things firsthand; he was interested in meeting Sultan Qaboos and hearing his positions on issues related to the Israeli-Arab conflict and the problems and threats in the Persian Gulf. After considerable efforts over a long period in 1994, the sultan agreed to a secret visit by the prime minister and a meeting with him. The visit was planned to last less than twenty-four hours, with most of the members of the prime minister's bureau not being privy to it. We left in the afternoon and returned the next morning. We landed at Muscat Airport near the sultan's private terminal, and from there we were taken to the palace.

The meeting and the dinner that followed were held in a circular space about thirty meters in diameter, with 360-degree glass walls and decorations, including rare arabesques, that made us feel as if we were staying in one of Harun al-Rashid's palaces.

After both sides exchanged thanks and niceties, Rabin offered the sultan his views on the state of the world, the Middle East, and the conflict, as well as his perceptions of threats and prospects. When Rabin spoke about the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, the sultan muttered that he did not support Palestinians coming to live in his country. He had apparently drawn conclusions from the Kuwaiti experience with the Palestinians in the first Gulf crisis of 1991, when the overwhelming majority of Palestinians who were allowed to remain in Kuwait and worked there in very lucrative jobs supported the Iraqi invasion. The Iranian issue was also discussed, and both sides agreed that an increasingly powerful Iran—certainly with nonconventional weapons—was indeed a threat. The sultan gave the impression that the Gulf States looked upon Israel as a force capable of stopping the Iranians. The two leaders agreed to stay in contact and to share their assessments through their representatives. Following the conversation, an unimaginably vast meal bursting with Middle Eastern aromas and